

TANTRAYA STUDY DOCUMENT

A Guide to Pranayama

A working guide to three pranayamas at the heart of the Tantraya practice: Nadi Shodhana, Kapalabhati, and Spinal Breathing. Here you will find the map of prana, nadis, chakras, koshas, and vayus that these practices work within, the full mechanics and staged progression of each technique, and the deeper aim they all point toward: a system calm, purified, and charged enough with prana that it no longer needs the breath to remain fully awake.

Every technique in this guide is taught the same way: calm, unforced, and built in careful stages. If any part of a practice ever asks you to strain, it has been misunderstood. Back off, and build again from ease.

PART ONE

Foundations

Prana, nadis, chakras, koshas, and vayus: the map of subtle energy, and how to prepare the body and mind to work with it.

PART THREE

Kapalabhati

Skull-Shining Breath: a calm, precise cleansing practice, built up through a careful bandha progression rather than force.

PART TWO

Nadi Shodhana

Alternate nostril breathing: the balancing, purifying practice that harmonizes Ida and Pingala and prepares the ground for deeper work.

PART FOUR

Spinal Breathing

The subtlest of the three practices: awakening and guiding prana along Sushumna Nadi, stage by stage.

Why Pranayama

Pranayama is usually translated as breath control, but its deeper meaning is “extension of prana”: the expansion of your vital energy. Within Tantraya, we treat it as a direct way of working with the life force that runs through thought, feeling, and body alike, not merely as a physiological exercise.

The old texts put it plainly: “All that exists in the three worlds rests in the control of prana.” Prana is the current running through everything alive, and learning to work with it consciously gives you a genuine tool: to clear your energetic pathways, calm the mind, and access capacities that usually stay dormant.

Pranayama works well alongside other Tantraya practices, either directly (holding a Kuji-in mudra while doing Spinal Breathing) or as part of a longer sequence: ten minutes of Nadi Shodhana, ten minutes of Kuji-in, ten minutes of Spinal Breathing, after warming up with Surya Namaskara. Rearrange the order to fit your own schedule.

A NOTE ON HOW THIS GUIDE TEACHES BREATH

Every technique in this guide is taught the same way: calm and unforced. Nothing here should ever require straining, gasping, or grimacing. If your face, jaw, or shoulders tighten, or your breath starts to feel like effort rather than ease, you have pushed past what your system is ready for. Back off, slow down, and let the practice rebuild itself gently from wherever it stopped working. Real capacity is built this way, patiently, not by pushing through strain.

Prana, Nadis, Chakras, and Koshas

Before working with pranayama directly, it helps to understand the energetic landscape it operates within. This isn't just theory; it's a map worth knowing before you start moving through the territory.

Nadis: The Channels

A network of subtle channels carrying prana through the body, said to number 72,000 or more. Three matter most in pranayama practice: Ida, Pingala, and Sushumna.

Prana: The Vital Energy

The energy that sustains life and consciousness, flowing through the nadis and chakras. Pranayama trains us to direct and expand it.

Chakras: The Centers. Located along the Sushumna Nadi, the chakras are centers of consciousness governing different aspects of physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual experience.

Ida Nadi

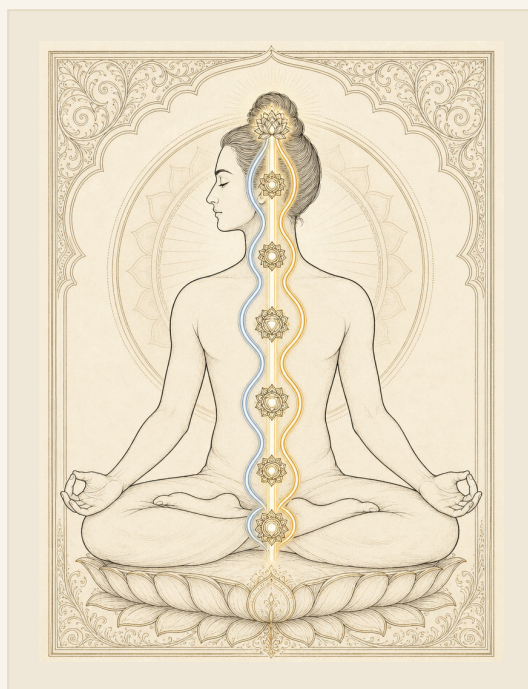
Runs from the base of the spine to the left nostril. Lunar, cooling, feminine. Governs mental energy, influences the right brain hemisphere, and supports the parasympathetic nervous system.

Pingala Nadi

Runs from the base of the spine to the right nostril. Solar, heating, masculine. Governs physical energy, influences the left brain hemisphere, and is linked to the sympathetic nervous system.

Sushumna Nadi

The central channel, running from the Muladhara chakra at the base of the spine to the Sahasrara chakra at the crown. When Ida and Pingala are balanced, prana can enter and rise through Sushumna, leading to deep meditative states. The Vasistha Samhita calls it Vaisnavi, the path of liberation.



Ida, Pingala, and Sushumna rising along the spine through the seven chakras, from Muladhara at the base to Sahasrara at the crown. This is the classical model, presented here as the general map.

A WORKING DISTINCTION: SUSHUMNA AND CHONG MAI

This general map is the classical picture, and it's worth knowing. In actual practice, though, this school draws a real distinction rather than treating every central channel as interchangeable. Sushumna refers specifically to the central subtle vessel running through the spine itself, a three-layered vessel, and it is Sushumna that Spinal Breathing works with directly. Nadi Shodhana and Kapalabhati, by contrast, work with a different central channel: Chong Mai, a term shared with qigong. Likewise, the left and right channels in Nadi Shodhana and Kapalabhati are not treated as winding down alongside the spine the way Ida and Pingala are sometimes pictured; they're closer to the left and right channels described in qigong and in Tibetan Buddhist yoga, straight rather than curved. Breath entering a nostril loops behind the eye on that side, then travels straight down, converging with Chong Mai at the lower dantien. You'll see this distinction applied concretely in each practice's own chapters.

The Koshas: Layers of Existence. Yogic philosophy describes the human being as made up of five layers, or koshas, that surround the true Self (Atman), from the most tangible to the most subtle.

- ① **Annamaya Kosha**
The physical sheath.
- ② **Pranamaya Kosha**
The vital energy sheath.
- ③ **Manomaya Kosha**
The mental sheath.
- ④ **Vijnanamaya Kosha**
The wisdom or intellect sheath.
- ⑤ **Anandamaya Kosha**
The bliss sheath, the most subtle layer.

Pranayama works mainly on the Pranamaya Kosha, but its effects ripple through the other layers too.

THE WEB OF SUBTLE ENERGY

Nadis, chakras, koshas, and vayus form one interconnected system. A blockage in one area, a nadi for example, affects the others: it can leave a chakra dormant or disturb the corresponding kosha. Pranayama is the tool for working with this whole system at once, purifying and balancing it through conscious attention to the breath.

PART ONE. FOUNDATIONS



The Five Prana Vayus

Within the Pranamaya Kosha, prana divides into five currents, or vayus, each with its own direction of flow, function, and area of the body.

Prana Vayu

Flows inward and upward. Governs intake (breath, food, impressions), respiration, and perception. Located in the head and chest.

Apana Vayu

Flows downward and outward. Governs elimination, grounding, and reproduction. Located in the pelvis and lower abdomen. Element: Earth.

Samana Vayu

Balances and assimilates, centered around the navel, governing digestion and integration.

Udana Vayu

Flows upward through the throat, governing speech, growth, and the capacity to rise, physically and spiritually.

Vyana Vayu

The distributive, circulatory current, carrying life force throughout the whole body and integrating the other four.

Neurology and Psychology of Breath

Pranayama's effects aren't confined to subjective or esoteric experience. Modern neurology and psychology are increasingly able to describe what's actually happening, and since the same underlying nervous system is at work no matter which of the three practices in this guide you're doing, it's worth laying out the whole picture here, once, rather than scattering fragments of it under each technique later.

Neurological Effects

Pranayama influences the autonomic nervous system (ANS). Different breathing techniques can selectively stimulate either the sympathetic nervous system (SNS, the “fight or flight” response) or the parasympathetic nervous system (PNS, the “rest and digest” response). Studies show pranayama can shift brainwave patterns toward alpha (relaxed awareness) and sometimes theta (deep meditation), and it improves heart rate variability (HRV), a key marker of cardiovascular health and stress resilience.

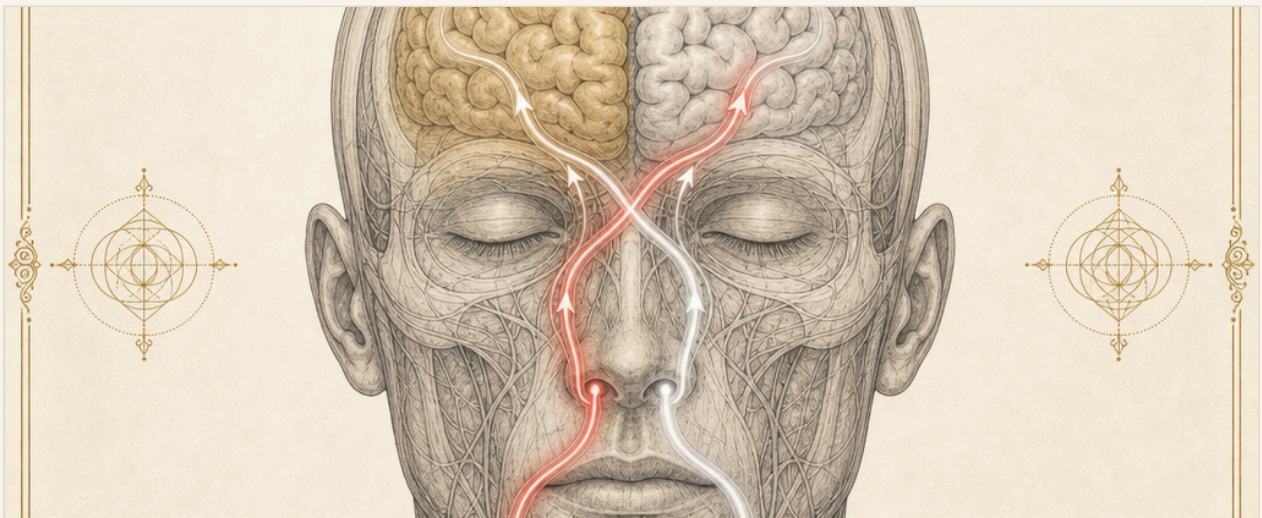
Psychological Benefits

Regular practice measurably reduces stress, anxiety, and depressive symptoms. It sharpens mental clarity, improves focus, and supports emotional regulation. Calming the mind and steadying the flow of thoughts creates an inner environment suited to introspection and self-awareness.

HATHA YOGA PRADIPIKA

“When the breath wanders, the mind is unsteady. When the breath is calmed, the mind too will be steady.” This is the foundational principle of pranayama: regulate the breath, and you directly influence the state of the mind.

Each of the three practices ahead engages this same nervous system a little differently, and it's worth seeing the whole picture before you begin any of them.



The crossing of currents just behind the eyes, not at the base of the skull: Pingala (white), carried by the right nostril, crossing to activate the left hemisphere; Ida (red), carried by the left nostril, crossing to activate the right hemisphere. This crossing is part of why alternate nostril breathing has such a direct effect on hemispheric balance.

Nadi Shodhana: Balancing

Alternate nostril breathing is well known for balancing the left and right brain hemispheres, supporting the interplay between logical and intuitive faculties. Its slow, rhythmic pattern, often with longer exhales or retention, shifts the ANS toward parasympathetic dominance, reducing stress and anxiety and building emotional stability.

Spinal Breathing: Deepening

Sustained practice, especially combined with bandhas, mudras, mantra, and visualization, strongly supports pratyahara (withdrawal of the senses), deepens dharana (concentration), and can lead into sustained dhyana (meditation). It calms the nervous system, balances brainwave activity, and can produce a state described as sukha-mana, a joyful, tranquil mind, as Sushumna activates. That joy isn't incidental; it's tied directly to real emotional and psychological wellbeing, arising from the balance created as the dual currents of Ida and Pingala merge into the single current of Sushumna.

Kapalabhati: Invigorating

The rapid, rhythmic exhales increase oxygen supply to the brain, producing alertness and mental clarity. Research has found reduced stress scores and improved cognitive function with regular practice, alongside an interesting pattern: initial sympathetic activation during the practice itself, followed by increased parasympathetic activity afterward. It's a gentle, invigorating conditioning of the nervous system, made more flexible and resilient without ever needing to be pushed into strain to get there.

The Common Thread

In every case the mechanism is the same at root: a change in breath pattern changes autonomic tone, which changes brainwave activity, which changes the felt quality of mind. The techniques differ in direction and intensity, but they're all working the same lever. This ground won't be repeated later in the same way, only technique-specific notes where something genuinely differs.

PART ONE. FOUNDATIONS



Preparing the Vessel: Asana, Mudra, Mindset

Before working with the finer techniques of pranayama, it's worth preparing the body and mind properly. Asana (posture), mudra (energetic gesture), and the right mindset aren't just preliminaries; they set the actual conditions pranayama needs to work.

Asana: Steadiness and Openness

A steady, comfortable seated posture is essential for sustained pranayama practice, letting the mind turn inward without physical distraction. Asana opens the nadis and chakras, clearing blockages that would otherwise interrupt the flow of prana. Spinal alignment in particular keeps the Sushumna Nadi clear, so energy can move upward unobstructed.

Mudra: Sealing and Directing Energy

Mudras are subtle gestures, mainly with the hands but also involving the eyes and body, that create energetic seals, redirecting prana and preventing it from dissipating. They deepen concentration and help turn the mind inward. Specific mudras play a direct role in guiding the breath, as you'll see in each practice in this guide.

Mindset: The Inner Foundation. Effective pranayama also depends on the right inner attitude.

Shraddha

Faith, trust, and respect for the practice and the tradition it comes from. This openness is what allows real receptivity.

Attentiveness

Sustained, unforced awareness directed at the breath and the subtle sensations that arise during practice.

Non-Striving

Patience, and letting go of the drive to force results. The deepest shifts tend to happen when you let the practice work through you rather than pushing for outcomes.

Regularity and Discipline

Consistency is what makes the cumulative effects of pranayama possible. Treat it as a steady commitment to yourself, not an occasional exercise.

These three, asana, mudra, and mindset, aren't just physical preparation. They're stages of genuine attunement, building the sensitivity you need to perceive and eventually direct prana. Real control of pranic force isn't available without bodily stability, mental steadiness, and precise attention, so these foundations are essential layers of the work, not optional extras.

PRACTICE ENVIRONMENT: A BASIC RULE OF HYGIENE

Pranayama works with the breath directly, so the quality of the air you breathe matters as much as the technique itself. Don't practice in polluted, smoky, or dirty environments; whatever you draw into the lungs during pranayama goes in deeper and stays longer than during ordinary breathing. Don't smoke, and give real practice time separation from any smoke you're exposed to. Where you can, practice outdoors, in clean air, ideally somewhere with good natural ventilation and some contact with growing things. Where that isn't available, at minimum practice in a clean, well-aired room. This isn't a minor housekeeping note; it's part of the practice itself.

PART ONE. FOUNDATIONS

VI

Bandha: Locking and Channeling Prana

Bandhas, or energetic locks, involve contracting specific muscle groups to seal and direct prana within the subtle body, especially along the Sushumna Nadi. We'll go deeper into bandhas within the individual practices, especially Kapalabhati and Spinal Breathing, but it's worth knowing their basic role from the start: they heighten your sensitivity to internal energy and build the foundation for more advanced pranic work.

Moola Bandha (Root Lock)

Conscious engagement of the pelvic floor, drawing energy upward from the base of the spine into the central channel.

Uddiyana Bandha (Abdominal Lock)

Lifting the abdominal organs upward and inward, creating a vacuum that draws prana from the lower centers toward the heart.

Jalandhara Bandha (Throat Lock)

Gently lowering the chin toward the chest while lifting the back of the head, sealing pranic currents within the torso and stimulating the throat center.

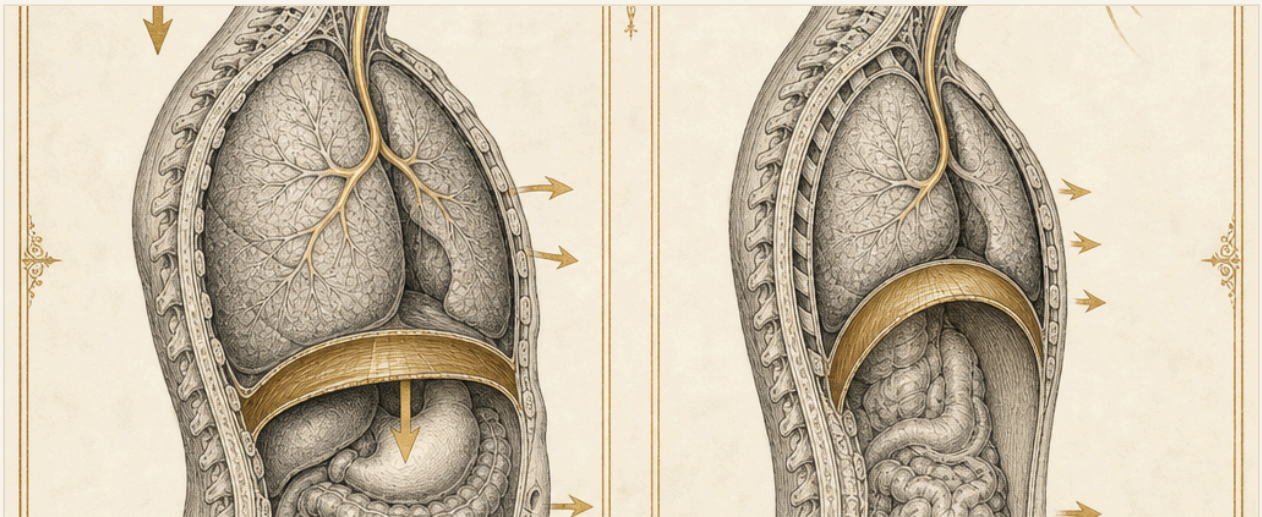
A WORD ON EFFORT

Every bandha in this guide is engaged gently. Moola Bandha in particular should never take more strength than a soft blink of the eyelid. If you find yourself gripping, clenching, or straining anywhere to hold a bandha, you're using more force than the practice calls for. Ease off until the lock is barely there, and let your sensitivity to it deepen with time rather than with muscular effort.

The Mechanics of Breathing: Diaphragm and Gaseous Exchange

Every practice in this guide rests on one physical fact: how the breath is actually mechanically taken. Before any nadi, bandha, or mudra, the raw material of pranayama is ordinary respiration, air moving in and out of the lungs. It is worth understanding this plainly, in the body's own terms, because a subtle practice built on a poor physical habit will only reinforce that habit.

Gaseous exchange is the actual physical purpose of breathing: oxygen from the air crosses into the bloodstream through the tiny air sacs of the lungs (alveoli), and carbon dioxide, a waste product of the body's own metabolism, crosses back out to be exhaled. This exchange happens far more completely, and far more efficiently, when the breath is slow, full, and diaphragmatic, drawing air deep into the lower and middle lobes of the lungs where the greatest concentration of alveoli sits. Shallow, high breathing, by contrast, moves air mainly through the upper lobes, leaves stale air sitting in the lower lungs, and forces the heart and nervous system to work harder for the same amount of usable oxygen.

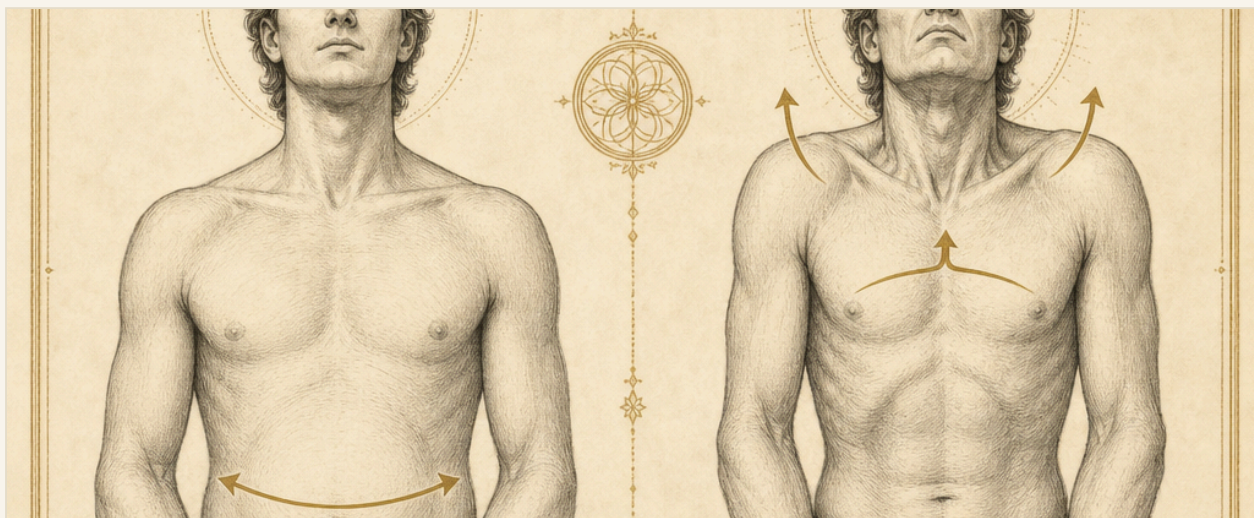


The diaphragm at work: on the inhale (left), the diaphragm contracts and flattens downward, the ribcage expands, and the lungs fill fully. On the exhale (right), the diaphragm relaxes back up into its domed shape beneath the lungs, gently pressing the air back out.

The diaphragm is the dome-shaped muscle separating the chest cavity from the abdominal cavity, and it is the true engine of the breath. On the inhale, it contracts and flattens downward, drawing air deep into the lungs and gently pressing the abdominal organs down and slightly forward, which is what produces the outward movement of the belly in correct breathing. On the exhale, the diaphragm simply relaxes, rising back into its natural dome shape, and the lungs empty as a natural consequence, with no need for extra muscular effort. This is why diaphragmatic breathing is also called “belly breathing,” even though, in truth, it is the diaphragm doing the work; the belly’s movement is just the visible sign of it.

WHERE STUDENTS GO WRONG

Almost every beginner, without correction, breathes at least partly with the chest, shoulders, neck, or face: lifting the chest and collarbones, hiking the shoulders up toward the ears, tensing the muscles of the neck and throat, or holding tension in the jaw, brow, and eyes. This is shallow, effortful, upper-lung breathing, and it directly activates the sympathetic nervous system, the very opposite of what pranayama is meant to cultivate. Students should never feel the shoulders rise, the neck tighten, or the face tense during any of the practices in this guide. If any of this is happening, slow down, drop the count, and return to simple diaphragmatic breathing until it becomes the body's default.



Correct diaphragmatic breathing (left): shoulders down and still, face and jaw soft, the belly moving gently outward on the inhale. Incorrect breathing (right): shoulders lifted, chest heaving, neck and face tense.

A SIMPLE SELF-CHECK

Rest one hand on the belly and one on the upper chest. On a natural breath, the hand on the belly should rise first and move the most; the hand on the chest should stay largely still. Shoulders should remain soft and heavy, the jaw loose, the brow unclenched, the throat open. Return to this check regularly, especially at the start of any session, until diaphragmatic breathing is simply how you breathe, in practice and in daily life.

PART TWO. NADISHODHANA

History and Mythology

Nadi Shodhana, “channel purification” or alternate nostril breathing, is one of the most fundamental and balancing pranayama practices. It cleanses the nadis, harmonizes Ida and Pingala, and prepares the mind and body for deeper meditation and energetic work.

Nadi Shodhana's roots run deep into yogic tradition. The Vasistha Samhita presents nadi purification as a dialogue between the sage Vasistha and his son, placing it as essential preparation before formal pranayama. The Gheranda Samhita, through a conversation between Sage Gheranda and King Chandrakapila, makes the same point: regulating prana is difficult if the nadis are impure. It describes two approaches: Samanu (with mantra) and Nirmanu (with cleansing technique).

The name itself explains the practice: “nadi” means a subtle channel, and “shodhana” means purification. The aim is to clear these pathways so prana can move freely.

PART TWO. NADISHODHANA



Ida and Pingala

Ida, the left channel, is called Chandra Nadi (the moon channel), carrying the qualities of Tamasa: inertia, coolness, receptivity. Pingala, the right channel, is Surya Nadi (the sun channel), carrying Rajasa: activity, heat, dynamism. The central channel this practice works with, Chong Mai, is beyond the duality of sun and moon. Nadi Shodhana balances the lunar and solar currents, which opens the way for prana to enter Chong Mai.

A NOTE ON HOW THESE CHANNELS ARE PICTURED HERE

It's common to picture Ida and Pingala winding down alongside the spine, the way Sushumna itself is pictured. That is not how this practice works with them. Here, Ida and Pingala are straight, in the manner of the left and right channels described in qigong and in Tibetan Buddhist yoga. Breath entering the left nostril loops back behind the left eye, then travels straight down toward the lower dantien; the right nostril mirrors this on the right. Sushumna, the spinal vessel proper, is reserved for Spinal Breathing later in this guide. What Nadi Shodhana and Kapalabhati work with is Chong Mai, the straight central channel running down the front of the torso.

Ida Nadi (Lunar Channel)

Associated with the left nostril, carrying cooling, calming, receptive energy (Shakti). Influences the right brain hemisphere, linked to intuition and holistic processing. Physiologically tied to the parasympathetic nervous system, inducing relaxation.

Pingala Nadi (Solar Channel)

Associated with the right nostril, carrying heating, stimulating, active energy (Shiva). Influences the left brain hemisphere, linked to logic and linear thinking. Tied to the sympathetic nervous system, mobilizing energy for action.

Most people have one of these dominant at any given time, which shows up as subtle shifts in energy, mood, and mental focus. Nadi Shodhana brings the two into balance, supporting the interplay between our intuitive and analytical faculties and between the calming and energizing branches of the nervous system.

PART TWO. NADISHODHANA



Posture and Hand Gestures

A stable, comfortable seated posture is essential: Siddhasana, Padmasana, Ardha Padmasana, or Sukhasana all work. If sitting on the floor is difficult, use a chair with feet flat on the ground, spine elongated. Keep the right elbow held slightly away from the body, not tucked against the ribcage, so the armpit stays open and the ribcage has room to expand fully; this is part of keeping the heart-meridian side of the body open and giving the lungs actual space to work in.

THE HAND GESTURE USED IN THIS GUIDE

Left hand: rest it on the left knee in Gyan Mudra, thumb tip and index fingertip touching lightly, the other three fingers extended, palm facing up, elbow held straight. (This assumes a right-handed practitioner; if you are left-handed, mirror the whole technique.)

THE RIGHT HAND

Bring the index and middle fingers of the right hand to rest lightly at the Ajna center, the point between the eyebrows. The ring finger and little finger, held together, are what open and close the left nostril. The thumb opens and closes the right nostril. Keep the right elbow held a little away from the body throughout, rather than pinned to the ribs.

ONE IMPORTANT CAUTION

The nose should stay straight throughout. Close each nostril with just enough pressure to seal the airflow, no more. If you find you're pressing hard enough to push the nose visibly sideways, you're using too much force. This is meant to be a light, precise touch, not a squeeze.



The hand position used in this guide: left hand in Gyan Mudra on the left knee, right hand's index and middle fingers resting at the Ajna center, thumb and ring/little finger ready at the nostrils, right elbow held away from the body.

PART TWO. NADISHODHANA

IV

The Five Progressive Stages

Build this practice carefully, one layer at a time. Each stage may take days or weeks to settle into before moving to the next, unless you have already worked with these stages before and are genuinely comfortable in them. Never rush the sequence for its own sake.

STAGE ONE: OBSERVING THE NATURAL BREATH

Sit with an erect spine, eyes gently closed. Bring your awareness to the natural flow of your breath without trying to control it. Notice the sensation in the left nostril (Ida): temperature, texture, whether it's open or restricted. Then do the same for the right nostril (Pingala). Finally, notice both at once. Notice, too, the natural length of your own inhale and your own exhale, and whether they are already equal or not. Focus: pure observation. Duration: 5–7 minutes. What it does: builds interoceptive awareness, the ability to sense your own internal state, and lets you notice any imbalance in nostril dominance, or in inhale/exhale length, before you start guiding the breath.

STAGE TWO: BALANCING INHALE AND EXHALE (1:1 RATIO, NO RETENTION)

Using the hand position described above, close the right nostril with the thumb. Exhale completely through the left. Inhale through the left for a comfortable count. Close the left nostril with the ring and little fingers, release the right, and exhale through the right for the same count. Inhale through the right for the same count. Close the right, release the left, exhale through the left for the same count. That's one round. Working from what you noticed in Stage One, settle on a count where both the inhale and the exhale are genuinely comfortable at the same length, neither rushed nor strained. Focus: smooth, silent, unstrained breath, with inhale and exhale matched in length. Duration: start with 5 minutes, building to 10–15 over days or weeks. What it does: equalizes the breath and begins to calm the nervous system by balancing the sympathetic and parasympathetic responses tied to Pingala and Ida.

Stage Three: Gentle Retention (1:1:1 Ratio). This stage introduces a hold equal in length to the inhale and the exhale, so the count becomes, for example, 1:1:1 (or 10:10:10). It is built in two sub-stages, given time to develop over days or weeks rather than rushed within a single sitting, unless you have already worked with retention before and are comfortable there.

1 Sub-stage 3a: Simply Holding the Inhale

Follow the Stage Two pattern, but add a brief hold (Antara Kumbhaka) after each inhalation, matching the length of the inhale and exhale: inhale left, hold, exhale right; inhale right, hold, exhale left. At this sub-stage, the hold is simply gentle and still: no inner movement of attention yet, just a quiet, comfortable pause.

Caution: introduce retention gently. The hold should feel comfortable, with no tension, gasping, or dizziness. If you feel strain, drop the count or return to Stage Two.

2 Sub-stage 3b: Attention Moving Up and Down the Central Channel

Once Sub-stage 3a is settled and comfortable, add an inner movement to the hold itself. Divide the hold in half: for the first half of the count, let your attention rise up through the central channel (Chong Mai); for the second half, let it descend back down through the central channel, arriving back at the base just as you release into the exhale. So if your count is ten, the hold is ten counts long: five counts rising up the central channel, five counts descending, and only then the exhale begins.

By this point in the sequence, a full round looks like this: the inhale enters through the left nostril, loops back behind the left eye, and travels straight down the left channel (Ida); you hold, with attention rising and then descending through the central channel (Chong Mai); the exhale travels straight down the right channel (Pingala), looping out behind the right eye and through the right nostril, for the same length as the inhale. Ida's path, for the purposes of this attention, runs roughly halfway between the front and back of the torso, and halfway between the side of the body and the center of the sternum, straight down, not winding around the spine. Pingala mirrors this on the right.

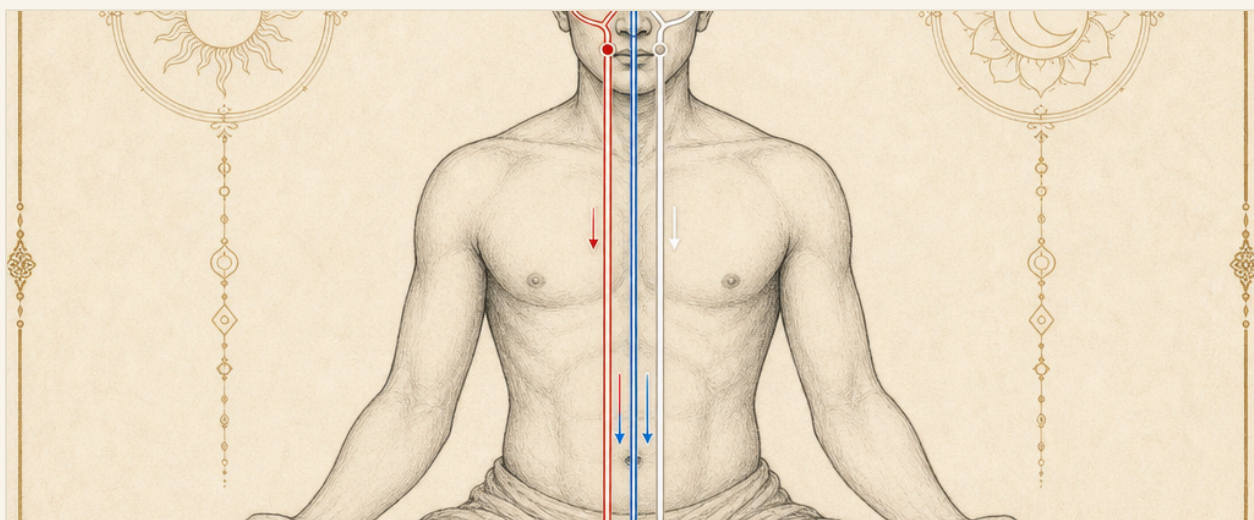
Stage Four: Visualizing the Three Channels. Once Stage Three is settled, add a clear inner visualization of the channels themselves. Remember that the visualization exists only to stimulate sensation and felt experience; it is not an end in itself.

The Three Channels, Visualized

- Ida, the left channel, is seen as red: breath enters the left nostril, loops back behind the left eye, then travels straight down the left side of the torso along the path described above.
- Pingala, the right channel, is seen as white, mirroring this on the right: entering the right nostril, looping behind the right eye, then straight down the right side.
- Chong Mai, the central channel, is seen as blue, running perfectly straight through the very center of the body, from behind the brow down to the lower dantien.
- The side channels, Ida and Pingala, are seen as narrow: roughly the width of a drinking straw. The central channel, Chong Mai, is seen as noticeably wider: closer to the width of a milkshake straw.
- All three channels are seen and felt as simple tubing, open and clear, prana moving through them the way a fluid moves through a tube. None of the three wind around the spine; all three run straight.
- As the breath descends through Ida on the inhale and through Pingala on the exhale, both channels curve inward toward the lower belly, the area of the lower dantien, and connect with the central channel there.

STAYING INSIDE THE BODY

Attention does not go out through the top of the head, and it does not go out through the perineum or the root. It stays inside the body throughout. Remind yourself, and remind any student you are guiding, not to let this visualization become something happening “in the head,” as an abstract picture. The aim is to actually see and feel these channels inside the body, as real as the sensation of the breath itself. This is not to say the channels only exist this way, or stay this way forever; in time, the practitioner comes to see that the body, the world, the whole universe, is itself contained within the central channel.



The three channels and the direction of the breath: Ida (red) carrying the inhale down the left side after looping behind the left eye, Pingala (white) carrying the exhale down the right after looping behind the right eye, Chong Mai (blue) running straight through the center, all three converging at a single point in the lower belly. Note that none of the three wind around the spine.

STAGE FIVE: WORKING WITH NEW RATIOS

Only once Stage Four is genuinely settled does the practitioner begin adjusting the ratio between inhale, hold, and exhale. The first ratio to work with is 1:2:1, an inhale, a hold twice as long, and an exhale equal to the inhale. Build to it in three careful steps, exactly as with the earlier stages: always go slowly and easily, and never let the pursuit of a ratio override the calm, unforced quality every stage before it was built on.

1 Extending the Exhale (1:2 Ratio, No Retention)

Return to the Stage Two pattern, but make the exhale twice as long as the inhale: inhale left, exhale right for twice the count; inhale right, exhale left for twice the count. Focus on a smooth, complete exhale without force. This has a strong calming effect and activates the parasympathetic nervous system.

2 Retention with Extended Exhale (1:1:2 Ratio)

Combine the Stage Three retention with the extended exhale above: inhale left, hold for the same count, exhale right for twice the count; inhale right, hold, exhale left for twice the count. Focus on seamless transitions.

3 The 1:2:1 Ratio

Adjust so the hold is twice the inhale, and the exhale matches the inhale: inhale left, hold for twice the count, exhale right for the same count as the inhale; inhale right, hold, exhale left. Focus on deep internal awareness and staying effortless despite the longer hold. This is where the real effect of Nadi Shodhana starts to show: mental quiet, heightened sensitivity, and a sense of expanded awareness.

ON GOING FURTHER

Traditional texts describe more advanced ratios beyond 1:2:1, such as 1:4:2 (Gheranda Samhita) or higher. These should only be attempted with an experienced teacher, after mastering 1:2:1 for a significant period. Pushing into advanced retention before your system is ready can genuinely harm you. I ended up in hospital with pneumonia in my younger, less careful years, from attempting advanced pranayama before I was ready for it. Please be careful.

PART TWO. NADISHODHANA



Mantra, Visualization, and Daily Practice

Beyond its neurological effects, Nadi Shodhana works directly on the subtle body. The finger placement and attention held at the Ajna center stimulate the seat of intuition and inner vision. As Ida and Pingala purify and balance, the blockages preventing energy from entering Chong Mai gradually dissolve. This purification is preparatory work, clearing and steadying the whole system, laying the ground for the deeper current, Sushumna proper, addressed directly later in Spinal Breathing. The practice also strengthens and balances the Vyana Vayu, the circulatory current that distributes prana through the whole body.

Mantra: So Hum

The universal mantra “So Hum” can be repeated mentally with the breath: “So” (That, or Universal Consciousness) with the inhale, “Hum” (I am) with the exhale. It affirms your connection to that universal essence and keeps the mind anchored in the practice.

Visualization

The core visualization for this practice is the one built up in Stage Four: Ida in red, Pingala in white, Chong Mai in blue, the side channels narrow, the central channel wide, all three straight, none of them winding around the spine, like open tubing carrying prana, with Ida and Pingala converging into Chong Mai at the lower dantien. Return to this image once it is established, rather than layering in new imagery; the aim is depth of feeling within one clear picture, not variety.

Best Time and Duration

Early morning, on an empty stomach, is traditionally the best time. Start with 5 minutes on the foundational stages, building to 10–15 minutes daily, extending to 20 or more as you advance.

Daily Integration

Notice the subtle shifts in energy, mood, and mental state through your day, not just during practice. Are you calmer, more centered, clearer? This kind of noticing is what actually integrates the practice into your life.

Nadi Shodhana is more than a breathing technique. Treated with reverence and consistency, it becomes a genuine tool for tuning your whole system toward balance and clarity.

PART THREE. KAPALABHATI



History and the Shatkarmas

Kapalabhati, sometimes translated as “Skull-Shining Breath,” is a dynamic pranayama technique and one of the six Shatkarmas (purification practices). It cleanses the respiratory system, energizes the mind, and brings a distinct clarity to your state of being.

“Kapal” means skull or forehead, and “bhati” means to shine or illuminate, which points at what the practice does: it cleanses physically and, traditionally, brightens the intellect.

Kapalabhati appears in classical texts including the Hatha Yoga Pradipika and the Gheranda Samhita, where it's categorized as one of the six Shatkarmas, purification techniques that clear the body of toxins and imbalance and prepare a practitioner for more advanced pranayama, mudra, bandha, and meditation. The Gheranda Samhita even credits it with “magical curative effects.” Its purpose goes beyond physical cleansing: it purifies the frontal region of the brain, clears the sinuses, removes excess phlegm, and supports mental clarity.

Some traditional sources, including the Hatha Yoga Pradipika, treat Kapalabhati more as a kriya (cleansing action) than a formal pranayama, since its most common form doesn't involve deliberate breath retention. Regardless of classification, its effect on breath and prana makes it a core part of breath training.

PART THREE. KAPALABHATI



The Mechanics of the Breath

Kapalabhati reverses the usual pattern of breathing. Where normal breathing is an active inhale and passive exhale, Kapalabhati flips that. But the reversal is in the direction of effort, not in its intensity: this is a calm, relaxed practice from the first breath to the last.

The Active Exhale

The breath is expelled through the nostrils with a light, brisk contraction of the abdominal muscles, drawing the navel gently toward the spine. This moves the diaphragm up and moves air out. The word to hold in mind here is brisk, not forceful. The action is quick and definite, but it should never feel like straining or pushing.

The Passive, Automatic Inhalation

After the exhale, the abdominal muscles relax, the diaphragm descends naturally, and the inhale happens on its own, without effort. All the deliberate work is in the exhale, and even that work stays light.

THE SINGLE RULE THAT GOVERNS THIS PRACTICE

All breathing in this guide, including Kapalabhati, is calm and relaxed. If your face screws up, your nose wrinkles, your jaw clenches, or your shoulders creep toward your ears, you are working too hard. Back off immediately. Slow the pace, shorten the round, or simply return to normal breathing and rest. There is no version of this practice where straining is the right response. Genuine progress in Kapalabhati is built through patient, relaxed repetition, not through effort or force.

To feel the underlying mechanism without any strain: inhale, purse your lips leaving a small opening, and let the breath out through it with a light push from the abdomen. You'll feel your abdomen tighten gently as it moves the air. Open your lips fully while continuing that same light action and you'll feel a small burst of air as the abdomen draws inward. That is the abdominal pump, and it should always feel closer to a light pulse than a shove.

PART THREE. KAPALABHATI



Posture and the Foundational Practice

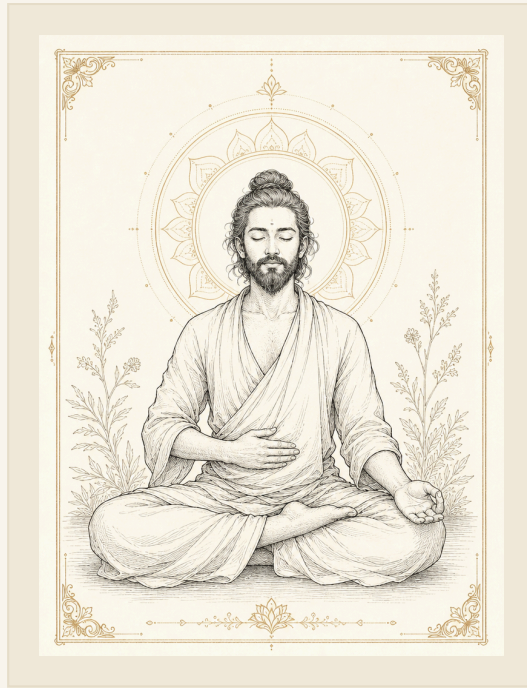
Posture

Sit cross-legged: Sukhasana, Siddhasana, Vajrasana, or Padmasana. Spine erect, shoulders relaxed, head centered.

Hands

Rest on the knees, palms up (Chin or Jnana Mudra) or down. You can place one hand on the abdomen at first to feel the muscle movement.

Preparation. Take a few calming breaths first. Practice on an empty stomach, ideally in the morning, and in a clean, well-aired space (see the note on practice environment in Part One).



The posture and inner attitude of Kapalabhati: erect spine, relaxed shoulders, a genuinely calm face, one hand free to feel the gentle abdominal movement.

Vatakrama Kapalabhati: The Foundational Practice. “Vata” means wind, “krama” means process; the name refers to cleansing the system through the breath. This is the most commonly practiced form.

- ① **Settle**
Sit with an erect spine, close your eyes, relax the body completely.
- ② **Inhale**
Take a gentle inhale through both nostrils, filling the lungs about halfway. Never more than 70–80 percent of your full capacity.
- ③ **Exhale, Lightly and Rhythmically**
Begin light, brisk exhalations through both nostrils, drawing the navel gently toward the spine with each one. Calm, not forceful.
- ④ **Let Inhalation Happen**
Let the inhale happen passively and automatically as the abdominal muscles relax after each exhale. It should be short and effortless.
- ⑤ **Keep a Steady, Easy Rhythm**
The effort is entirely in the exhale, and it stays light throughout; the inhale is a natural recoil.
- ⑥ **Complete a Round**
See the exhale-count progression in the next chapter, which replaces any fixed target with a careful, staged build.
- ⑦ **Close the Round**
After the last exhale, follow the bandha sequence described in the next chapter before returning to normal breathing.
- ⑧ **Rest**
Rest for 30 seconds to a minute, noticing any lightness, clarity, or energy in the head.
- ⑨ **Repeat**
Repeat for your intended number of rounds, starting around 3.

PART THREE. KAPALABHATI

IV

The Bandha Progression

Kapalabhati deepens by adding bandhas to the round, one at a time, over a sequence of sessions. Build this progression patiently. Each addition should feel like a natural next layer, not a new challenge to push through.

EXHALE COUNTS: A STAGED BUILD, NOT A RACE

Set aside any idea of building toward 60 or 100 exhalations quickly. Start at 15 exhalations per round (the inhale, as always, happens on its own). Once 15 feels completely easy and relaxed across several sessions, move to 20. Once 20 feels easy, move to 25. Beyond 25, you may gently build your own capacity further over time, always guided by ease rather than ambition, and always keeping the 70–80 percent capacity rule from the previous chapter.

Add the bandhas progressively, across separate stages of practice, in this order:

1 Stage 1: Moola Bandha on the Exhale

As you perform your rounds, add a gentle lift of the pelvic floor, inward and upward, on each exhalation only. No more strength than a soft blink of the eyelid.

2 Stage 2: Moola Bandha on the Inhale

Once Stage 1 is comfortable, within the same session, also apply the same gentle Moola Bandha lift on the inhale.

3 Stage 3: Moola Bandha Throughout

Combine the two: hold the same light pelvic floor lift continuously, through both the exhale and the inhale of every breath in the round.

4 Stage 4: The Held Inhale, with Full Bandha Sequence

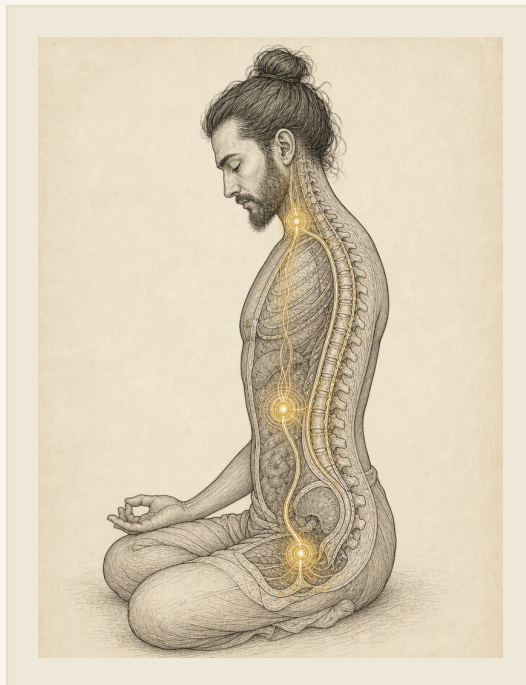
At the end of the round, on the inhale, take the breath in and hold it, engaging the bandhas in order: pelvic floor first, then Uddiyana Bandha, then Jalandhara Bandha (the chin lock).

WHY UDDIYANA FEELS DIFFERENT HERE

On this held inhale, the belly is full, not empty. So Uddiyana Bandha here isn't the negative-pressure inward draw you feel when applying it on an empty stomach; instead, the lift draws gently toward the spine and toward Ming Men (the low back point opposite the navel), working with the fullness rather than against it.

THE JALANDHARA CUE: LIFT THE JADE PILLOW

As you apply the chin lock, the important cue is this: lift the jade pillow, the occiput, the back of the head, upward, so that the chin drops down as a result of that lift, rather than the head simply dropping forward. If you just drop the head, the chin tends to rise rather than tuck, which is the opposite of what you want. Keep the front and back of the neck both long as you do this; there should be no crunching or compression at the throat.



The three-lock sequence: pelvic floor at the base, Uddiyana Bandha at the navel drawing toward the spine, and Jalandhara Bandha at the throat, engaged in that order on the held inhale.

After the held inhale, with all three bandhas engaged, hold only as long as remains genuinely comfortable. Then exhale, take one or two normal, easy breaths, and only then begin the next round.

RELEASE ORDER: ALWAYS THE REVERSE

Bandhas release in the reverse order from how they were engaged: throat first, then the abdomen, then the pelvic floor. Release Jalandhara Bandha, then Uddiyana Bandha, then finally the pelvic floor lift. Never release out of this order.

Refining Moola Bandha: Isolating the Pelvic Floor. Most students begin by lifting the whole pelvic floor together as one undifferentiated unit, since the parts can't yet be told apart. That's the correct starting point; don't rush past it. Over time, cultivate the ability to isolate specific parts of that same lift:

- Lifting the anus in and up, without engaging the perineum.
- Lifting the perineum without engaging the anus.
- Lifting the front of the pelvic floor (penis or vagina) without engaging the perineum.

This isolation work is slow and subtle. Treat it as its own quiet practice within the practice, not something to force in a single sitting.

THE NEXT STAGE: THE SAME SEQUENCE ON THE EXHALE RETENTION

Once the held-inhale version of this sequence is well established, the next stage applies the identical bandha sequence, pelvic floor, then Uddiyana, then Jalandhara, on the exhale retention instead: the breath held out, lungs empty, held for as long as remains genuinely comfortable.

THE CRITICAL RULE FOR COMING OUT OF AN EXHALE RETENTION

Do not take a fast or heavy inhalation immediately after releasing a breath-held-out retention. First release Jalandhara Bandha, then release Uddiyana Bandha fully, letting the belly pop back out. Only once the belly has genuinely released should you begin to inhale, and that inhale itself is taken in two distinct parts, with no exhale between them: a gentle inhale through the mouth to about 30 percent of capacity, followed by a second gentle inhale that completes the breath. This two-part inhale protects the system from the kind of sudden pressure change that a single fast gasp would create.

Never breathe beyond 70–80 percent of full lung capacity in any pranayama practice in this guide. There is no benefit hidden on the far side of strain.

PART THREE. KAPALABHATI

V

Benefits and Contraindications

Benefits

Respiratory: cleanses the lungs and sinuses, removes excess mucus, improves lung capacity. Digestive: stimulates the abdominal organs, aids metabolism. Mental: energizes the mind, sharpens focus and memory, reduces stress. Energetic: clears the nadis, stimulates the Manipura and Ajna chakras, balances Kapha dosha.

Contraindications

Avoid or practice only with extreme caution if you have high or low blood pressure, heart disease, or a history of stroke. Avoid during pregnancy or menstruation, with hernia, gastric ulcer, recent abdominal surgery, or a slipped disc, or with epilepsy, vertigo, migraines, detached retina, glaucoma, or significant nosebleeds.

A STANDING CAUTION

Given its power, learn Kapalabhati under a qualified teacher if you have any of the conditions above, and check with your healthcare provider first. Stop immediately if you feel any strain, gasping, dizziness, or tension anywhere in the face, neck, or shoulders. The whole practice, exhale, bandhas, and all, should stay within a calm and relaxed range throughout.

Beyond its neurological effects, Kapalabhati works directly on the subtle body.

Manipura Chakra

The light pumping abdominal action stimulates this center at the solar plexus, the seat of personal power, vitality, and digestive fire (Agni). Activating it can boost confidence, energy, and digestion.

Ajna Chakra Connection

The “skull-shining” effect points to the eyebrow center. Stimulation here is said to sharpen the intellect and deepen inner awareness.

Nadi Cleansing

Highly effective at clearing blockages in the subtle energy channels, supporting the free flow of prana.

Balancing Kapha

In Ayurvedic terms, Kapalabhati reduces excess Kapha dosha, the quality of heaviness and congestion, by clearing phlegm and invigorating the system.

Kapalabhati is best practiced on an empty stomach, usually in the morning, and integrates well into a broader practice sequence. As you deepen the practice, follow the staged bandha progression from the previous chapter rather than simply chasing higher exhale counts; the bandha work is where the real depth of this practice is found.

PART FOUR. SPINAL BREATHING

Kriya Pathways and Sushumna Nadi

Spinal Breathing is the most subtle of the three practices in this course. Central to various Kriya Yoga traditions, it's a method for awakening and guiding prana along the Sushumna Nadi, the main channel toward higher consciousness. It asks for focused attention, refined awareness, and real patience.

Kriya Yoga is an advanced system of pranayama, mantra, and mudra aimed at accelerating spiritual development. “Kriya” means activity or movement, referring specifically to the conscious movement of awareness and prana along particular energetic pathways.

At the center of these pathways is the Sushumna Nadi, running through the core of the spine itself. Where Ida and Pingala govern the dualistic energy of everyday experience, Sushumna is the channel for awakened spiritual energy, often called Kundalini. As prana moves up through Sushumna, it activates the chakras in sequence, producing real shifts in consciousness.

SUSHUMNA, SPECIFICALLY

Worth being precise here, since this practice is the one place in the guide that works with Sushumna directly. Sushumna is not the same channel as Chong Mai, the central channel worked with in Nadi Shodhana and Kapalabhati. Sushumna is the subtle vessel running through the spine itself, and it is described here as having three layers, or levels: the outer, physical-adjacent layer, a subtler inner layer, and the innermost, most refined core. Spinal Breathing works with all three over time, and it is this spinal vessel, not Chong Mai, that carries Kundalini as it rises.

The modern spread of Kriya Yoga traces largely to the lineage of Mahavatar Babaji, who initiated Lahiri Mahasaya in the 19th century. Lahiri Mahasaya taught Sri Yukteswar Giri, the guru of Paramahansa Yogananda, whose Autobiography of a Yogi brought Kriya Yoga to a wide international audience. Swami Satyananda Saraswati of the Bihar School of Yoga also taught Kriya Yoga drawn from earlier Yoga and Tantra texts. These lineages differ in technical detail but share the same aim: using breath and awareness to activate Sushumna and raise consciousness.

PART FOUR. SPINAL BREATHING



Preparing for the Ascent

Spinal Breathing's subtlety means preparation matters more here than in the other two practices.

Asana

A stable, comfortable, erect meditative posture, such as Siddhasana, Padmasana, or Ardha Padmasana, is essential. The spine must be straight and unstrained so prana can move freely along Sushumna.

Mudra

Shambhavi Mudra is built into the practice itself, but preparatory mudras such as Jnana Mudra or Chin Mudra can support concentration in the hands.

Mental Stillness. A calm, introverted mind is essential. Nadi Shodhana is an excellent prerequisite, since it balances the nadis and quiets mental chatter. Any agitation makes it hard to perceive and guide the subtle currents this practice depends on.

The physiological correlates of these traditional claims are being studied directly. Research on slow diaphragmatic breathing and alternate nostril breathing has shown measurable increases in “spinal energy levels” across regions of the spine, connecting the traditional yogic model of pranic flow to modern bioenergetics. Gazing techniques like Bhramadhya (eyebrow center) focus are thought to influence cerebrospinal fluid flow, and known effects of deep rhythmic breathing, retention, and focused attention on the autonomic nervous system, brainwave states, and neuroendocrine balance give a real scientific frame for understanding the calming and focusing effects reported in this practice.

The Eleven Progressive Stages

Build this practice one careful layer at a time. Each stage may take days, weeks, or longer to settle into before adding the next, unless you have already worked with these elements and are genuinely comfortable in them. Every stage is built on the diaphragmatic breathing described earlier in this guide: the shoulders, neck, and face stay soft and uninvolved throughout.

STAGE ONE: OBSERVING THE SPINAL CHANNEL

Sit erect, eyes closed, breathing naturally. Simply observe the Sushumna, the central channel running through the spine, as you inhale and as you exhale, without yet trying to move breath or attention along it in any particular way. Notice whatever sensation, however faint, is already there. Focus: pure observation of the central channel. What it does: establishes the central channel as a real, felt presence before you begin guiding energy through it.

STAGE TWO: THE BASIC RISING AND FALLING BREATH

Inhale gently, letting the breath and attention rise up through the central channel as the lungs fill fully and gently, with no straining for a maximal inhale. Exhale, letting the breath and attention descend back down through the central channel as the lungs empty fully. Focus: a smooth, unforced, full rise on the inhale and full fall on the exhale, entirely within the central channel. What it does: establishes the basic rhythm every later stage builds on.

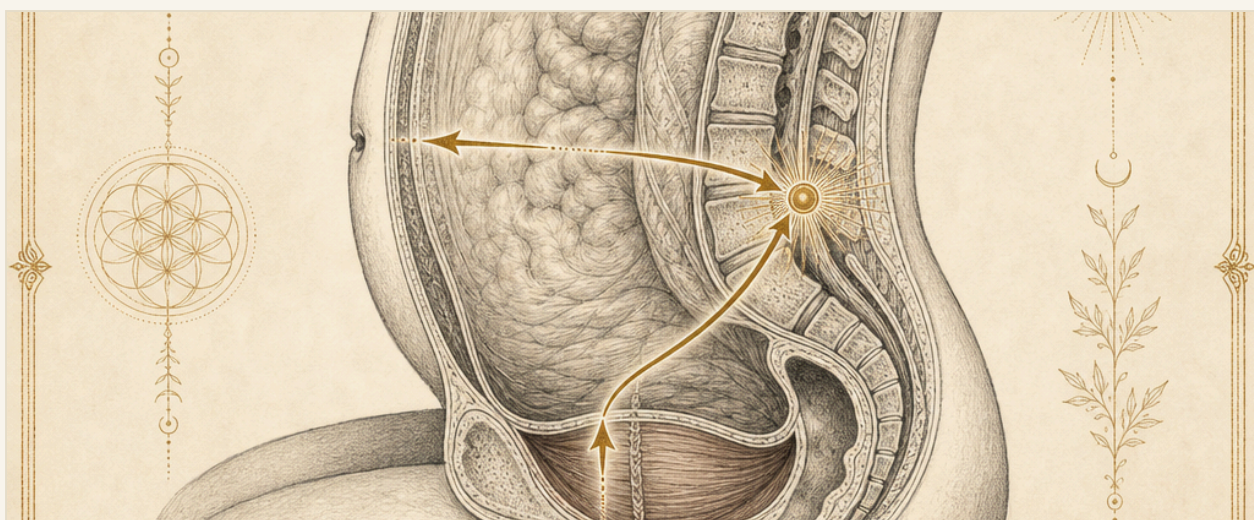
Stage Three: Gentle Hold at the Top. Continue the Basic Rising and Falling Breath, and add a gentle hold at the end of the inhale, before the exhale begins. The hold should be soft and brief, with no tension anywhere in the body.

Stage Four: Gentle Hold at the Bottom. Once Stage Three is settled, add a matching gentle hold at the end of the exhale, before the next inhale begins. As with Stage Three, this hold stays soft, brief, and entirely unstrained.

Stage Five: Moola Bandha on the Inhale. Return to the basic rising and falling breath, and add Moola Bandha, a subtle contraction of the pelvic floor, engaged gently throughout the inhale only, releasing as the exhale begins.

Stage Six: Moola Bandha on the Exhale. Once Stage Five is settled, reverse the placement: engage Moola Bandha gently throughout the exhale only, releasing as the next inhale begins.

Stage Seven: Moola Bandha Through Both. Once Stages Five and Six are both comfortable, combine them: Moola Bandha stays gently engaged through both the inhale and the exhale, a continuous, soft lift at the pelvic floor.



The felt direction of the locks used in these stages: the pelvic floor drawing gently upward, the lower belly drawing gently back toward the spine, both converging toward a single point at Ming Men, the “gate of life” on the lower back, opposite the navel.

Stage Eight: Hold at the Top, with Moola Bandha. Combine Stage Three's gentle hold at the top of the inhale with the continuous Moola Bandha from Stage Seven, so the lock is already engaged as you arrive at the hold and simply continues through it.

Stage Nine: Hold at the Bottom, with Moola Bandha. Combine Stage Four's gentle hold at the bottom of the exhale with the same continuous Moola Bandha, so the lock carries you through the pause at the bottom just as it did at the top.

STAGE TEN: THE FULL BANDHA SEQUENCE AFTER THE INHALE

After a full, gentle inhale, apply the bandhas in this order: root (Moola Bandha) first, then belly (Uddiyana Bandha, drawing the lower belly back toward the spine and gently up), then neck (Jalandhara Bandha, chin easing toward the chest, lifted from the back of the skull, the “jade pillow” cue). Hold gently. Then release in the same order they were applied: root, then belly, then neck. Only once all three have been released do you allow a gentle exhale. After the exhale, take one or two normal, easy breaths before beginning the next round. This mirrors, in the same three-lock order, the bandha sequence taught for Kapalabhati earlier in this guide.

STAGE ELEVEN: THE FULL BANDHA SEQUENCE AFTER THE EXHALE, WITH THE TWO-STAGE INHALE

After a full, gentle exhale, apply the same three-lock sequence, root, belly, neck, and hold gently. Release all three in reverse order: neck first, then belly, then root. Then inhale in two distinct stages: first draw the inhale to roughly 30 percent of full capacity through the mouth, then, without exhaling in between, continue the same inhale on to roughly 70–80 percent of full capacity. Never exceed this 70–80 percent mark. Build the number of breaths gradually across sessions: fifteen breaths in the first round, twenty in a later round, twenty-five in a further round still, always staying well inside your comfortable capacity rather than pushing toward it.

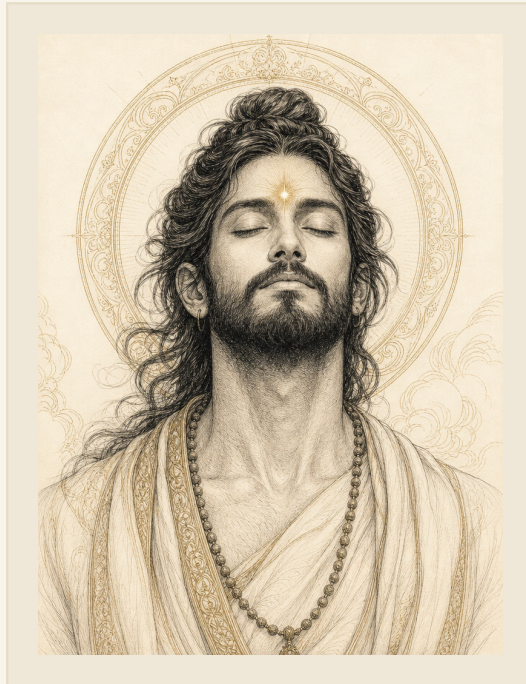
As with every stage before it, none of this is to be rushed. Move to a new stage only once the one before it feels settled, easy, and free of strain, even if that takes considerably longer than a single sitting.

Refining the Practice: Gaze and the Medulla-to-Third-Eye Pathway

Once the Eleven Progressive Stages are genuinely settled, two further refinements deepen the practice. Neither replaces the core sequence; both are added on top of it.

Adding Shambhavi Mudra. Alongside the stages above, add Shambhavi Mudra (eyebrow center gazing): turn the eyes gently upward and inward toward the point between the eyebrows (Bhrumadhya), with the head still and no strain anywhere in the eyes or brow. This can be practiced with the eyes lightly closed, or lightly open, gazing softly toward the eyebrow center.

Purpose: Shambhavi Mudra awakens the Ajna Chakra, the seat of intuition and inner guidance, and helps still the mind and withdraw the senses. Focus: sustained, gentle awareness at the eyebrow center. If eye strain occurs, release the mudra, relax, and re-engage gently.



Shambhavi Mudra: the gaze turned gently inward and upward toward the Ajna center, without strain in the eyes.

The Medulla-to-Third-Eye Pathway. This refinement adds a more specific pathway found in certain Kriya lineages: breathing up the spine to the back of the head, then forward to the third eye, then back down.

1

Inhale

Visualize the pranic current rising through Sushumna from Muladhara specifically to the medulla oblongata, at the base of the skull.

2

Transition

From the medulla, visualize the current moving forward through the center of the brain to the Ajna Chakra, pausing briefly there if you wish.

3

Exhale

Visualize the current descending from Ajna back down through Sushumna to Muladhara.

This pathway echoes techniques associated with Paramahansa Yogananda, where energy is directed through specific brain centers, and aspects of Maha Mudra as taught by Swami Satyananda Saraswati. Focus: intense concentration on the path itself, maintaining the bandhas and Shambhavi Mudra throughout. What it does: can lead to very deep introversion and meditation; this specific stimulation is intended to affect consciousness directly and accelerate spiritual development.

PARTFOUR.SPINALBREATHING

V

Key Bandhas in Spinal Breathing

Moola Bandha (Root Lock)

At the perineum or cervix. Locks Apana Vayu, prevents prana's downward escape, redirects it upward into Sushumna, and awakens Muladhara Chakra.

Jalandhara Bandha (Throat Lock)

The chin gently lowered to the sternal notch, lifted from the back of the head rather than dropped from the front. Prevents prana from escaping upward prematurely, directs it into the torso, stimulates the thyroid and parathyroid, and calms mind and heart.

Uddiyana Bandha (Abdominal Lock)

After a full exhale, the abdomen drawn inward and upward. Lifts prana powerfully through Sushumna, stimulates Manipura Chakra, and is considered highly powerful, worth building toward gradually.

PARTFOUR.SPINALBREATHING

VI

Drawing Up the Energy: From Mist to Deeper Substances

Once the Eleven Progressive Stages, the bandha sequence, and the refinements above are all genuinely stable, a further layer of practice becomes available: drawing the energy itself up through the central channel in a felt, almost substantial form, rather than as breath or light alone. This is a later stage of the work, and it develops in its own careful sequence.

1 Very Light Mist

The first form in which this rising energy is felt: something like a very fine, light mist, barely more substantial than the breath itself, drawn up through the central channel on the inhale and the held ascent.

2 Like Water

As sensitivity deepens, the same rising current begins to feel more like water: a thin, flowing substance with more presence and continuity than mist.

3 Like Milk

Further along, the felt quality thickens again, taking on something like the texture of milk: fuller, more nourishing, more clearly substantial.

4 Thicker, Heavier Substances

With time, the sensation can deepen further still, into thicker and heavier felt substances, drawn up the central channel with the same care and the same unforced attention as every earlier stage.

5 Sexual Energies and Fluids

Much later still, for those for whom it is appropriate, this same drawing-up can extend to sexual energy and fluid itself. This is a genuinely advanced application, not a starting point, and not something to approach quickly or casually.

A NECESSARY CAUTION ON TIMING AND READINESS

This is not a sequence to hurry toward. For most practitioners, meaningful, safe work with these deeper substances, particularly the final stage involving sexual energy, is realistically a year or two of steady, unforced practice away, and for some considerably longer. Before approaching it, the body needs to be genuinely soft, open, flexible, and strong: not tense, not rigid, not straining to arrive somewhere ahead of its own readiness. Move through mist, water, and milk fully before considering anything beyond them, and do so under the guidance of a teacher who can assess your actual readiness rather than your enthusiasm for the idea of it.

PART FOUR. SPINAL BREATHING

VII

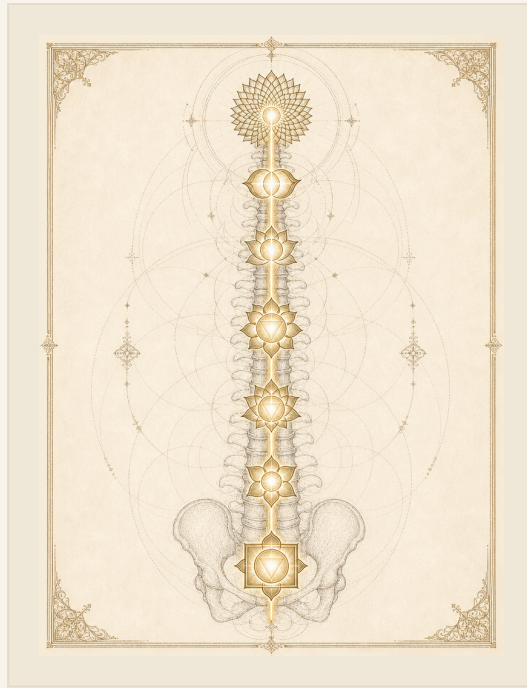
Mantra and the Chakra Journey

Mantra

Om Japa: mentally chant Om with each phase of the breath, or as awareness moves through the chakras. So'ham ("I am That"): "So" with the inhale (ascent), "Ham" with the exhale (descent), fostering identification with universal consciousness.

Visualization

Picture the pranic current as a stream of white or golden light, intensifying as it passes each chakra. Bring awareness to each chakra as energy moves through it, visualizing it as a spinning wheel of light in its traditional color, or working with its bija (seed) mantra.



The seven chakras along Sushumna Nadi, each visualized in its traditional lotus form as the pranic current rises and descends.

Muladhara (Base)

Perineum. Earth, bija LAM. A red lotus, grounding and stability.

Svadhisthana (Sacral)

Lower abdomen. Water, bija VAM. An orange crescent moon, fluid and creative.

Manipura (Solar Plexus)

Navel area. Fire, bija RAM. A yellow, ten-petaled sun, transformative heat.

Anahata (Heart)

Chest center. Air, bija YAM. A green, twelve-petaled lotus, expansive and open.

Vishuddha (Throat)

Throat region. Ether, bija HAM. A blue, sixteen-petaled lotus, vast and resonant.

Ajna (Third Eye)

Eyebrow center. Light and mind, bija OM. An indigo, two-petaled lotus, clarity and intuition.

Sahasrara, the crown, is felt rather than pictured with a single form: a thousand-petaled lotus radiating white and violet light, where individual consciousness merges with the universal. The Yoga Tattva Upanishad describes concentration on the five elements within specific regions of the body in a similar way, linking them to seed mantras and deities.

Beyond its neurological and psychological effects, Spinal Breathing carries a spiritual dimension that the other two practices only touch on. It's a core technique for awakening Kundalini Shakti, the dormant energy at the base of the spine. As it rises through Sushumna and pierces the chakras, it can lead to expanded consciousness and, ultimately, the potential for self-realization.

The layering of bandhas, mudras, breath pathways, and visualization in this practice is a genuinely well-designed system, built to systematically withdraw consciousness from the senses and redirect it inward along Sushumna. Each element serves a specific function in that process. This combination of pratyahara and dharana is what opens into dhyana and, ultimately, samadhi, as outlined in classical yoga. This is what Yogananda and other Kriya masters mean by the “science” of Kriya.

A STANDING CAUTION

The power of Spinal Breathing, especially anything Kundalini-related, calls for a slow, careful, well-guided approach. Undertaken incorrectly or too soon, these practices carry real risk of adverse effects, sometimes called “Kundalini syndrome.” Building this practice piece by piece, with full embodiment at each stage, matters even more here than in Nadi Shodhana or Kapalabhati. A teacher who can assess your readiness and guide you properly is genuinely important at this level.

PART FOUR. SPINAL BREATHING

VIII

The Breathless State

There's a deeper aim running underneath everything in this guide, worth naming plainly. Pranayama is not designed simply to make you good at breathing exercises. It's designed to bring enough prana into the body, and refine your relationship with it enough, that breathing itself is no longer needed to sustain the state you're in.

As prana accumulates and the nervous system settles into genuine stillness, the demand for oxygen exchange drops, and with it, the pull of the breath. Practiced deeply enough, over enough time, a practitioner falls naturally into what's called the breathless state: periods where breathing simply stops, not through force or holding, but because the system, for that time, has no need of it.

THE BREATHLESS STATE AND SAMADHI

This breathless state is equated, in the tradition, with samadhi: a superconscious condition. One useful way to approach what that actually means is this: it is equal to being aware, awake, and lucid within what would otherwise be deep, dreamless sleep. In ordinary deep sleep, the body rests completely and consciousness itself seems to disappear along with it. In samadhi, that same total bodily rest and cessation of ordinary breath happens, but awareness itself remains fully present and awake within it, rather than going dark.

It's worth being honest that samadhi is not one single, uniform state. Like most things in this territory, it has real depth and gradation: what opens up in an early, brief taste of stillness is not the same as what a lifetime of practice can eventually reveal. Don't mistake an early glimpse for the whole of what's possible, and don't discount an early glimpse either, simply because deeper ground exists beyond it. Both are real, at their own depth.

This is the actual horizon that Nadi Shodhana, Kapalabhati, and Spinal Breathing are all quietly pointing toward, each in **PART FIVE. INTEGRATION AND TEACHING** balanced, and charged with prana that it can, for a time, set breathing down entirely, and remain fully awake while it does.

FURTHER READING

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Further Reading and Resources

This teaching draws on the classical sources of hatha yoga and pranayama, and on the living Tantraya lineage that carries the same current forward. The following are warmly recommended for those who wish to go deeper.

Classical and Traditional Sources

- **Hatha Yoga Pradipika**, trans. various. The core classical manual on hatha yoga practice, including Kapalabhati and the wider Shatkarmas.
- **Gheranda Samhita**, trans. various. A detailed classical treatise on the Shatkarmas, pranayama, mudra, and bandha, including Samanu and Nirmanu approaches to Nadi Shodhana.
- **Vasistha Samhita**, trans. various. Presents nadi purification as a dialogue between Sage Vasistha and his son, foundational to the Nadi Shodhana teaching.
- **Yoga Tattva Upanishad**, trans. various. Describes concentration on the elements within the body and their links to seed mantras and chakras.
- **A Systematic Course in the Ancient Tantric Techniques of Yoga and Kriya**, Swami Satyananda Saraswati. A thorough modern treatment of pranayama, bandha, and kriya within the Bihar School lineage.
- **Autobiography of a Yogi**, Paramahansa Yogananda. Brought Kriya Yoga and the lineage of Mahavatar Babaji and Lahiri Mahasaya to wide international audience.

On the Nervous System and the Physiology of Breath

- **Physiological Mechanisms of Pranayama: A Narrative Review**, PMC. A review of how pranayama techniques act on the autonomic nervous system, brainwave states, and heart rate variability.
- **Neuro-cardiovascular-respiratory Responses to Bhastrika Pranayama in Regular Yoga Practitioners**, PMC. Research on the physiological effects of rapid, bellows-type pranayama on practitioners.
- **Scientific Basis of Kapalabhati Pranayama: A Narrative Review**, PMC. A review of the documented physiological and cognitive effects of Kapalabhati.
- **Comparative Neurodynamic Analysis of Spinal Energy Enhancement in Experienced Yoga Practitioners Using Various Breathing Techniques**, ResearchGate. Research measuring changes in spinal energy correlates across breathing techniques, relevant to the traditional model of pranic flow along Sushumna.